How to read the Hub

A five-minute orientation: what each section is, what is decided versus what is being discussed, how to open and drive the prototype, and how to tell the design team what you think.

Last updated 1 November 2026 · Owner: Jill Moreno, UX Design — the design lead

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01 What you are looking at

This is the design team's front door for the **XCEL learner platform** — the next-generation LMS for insurance, mortgage and banking pre-licensing and continuing education. It is a working prototype, not the shipped product: real screens, real interaction, demo data.

Who is who. Each surface of the product has a **designer** who owns it. The **design lead** (Jill Moreno) owns the project itself — the code repository on GitHub and its released copy, `main` — and is the one person who releases work into the product. When this page says "the team", it means the five designers; when it says "the design lead", it means her.

The page has a left-hand rail of sections, in four groups, and a main area showing whichever one is selected. It opens on **Prototypes**, because that is the thing most people come to see. There is one Hub, behind one password, and everyone — the design team, developers, and you — sees the same thing.

THE ONE DISTINCTION THAT MATTERS

Prototypes is what the team has landed on. **Refinement** is what the team is still discussing. Everything else on this page is supporting material. If you only remember one thing, remember that.

Prototypes itself has two views, chosen by the **Main · Stage** switch above its rows. **Main** is the released product. **Stage** is what the surface owners have decided and are waiting to release — a preview of the next Main. Same rows either way; the switch picks which build they open.

02 The sections you will use

SECTION	WHAT IT IS	HOW TO READ IT
Prototypes	The product as it currently stands — one row per surface of it: the end-to-end journey, the invite and purchase flow, Atlas Learning, Compass Learning, and the admin tool. Every row opens the same build — Main (released) or Stage (decided, not yet released), by the switch above the rows.	Main is the agreed baseline. Nothing appears on it by accident — every element was a decision, and changing it is a deliberate release by the design lead. Stage is what Main will be next; a designer who owns a surface puts their decided work there, and the design lead releases it.
Refinement	Work in review — a list of links to designs the team is discussing. Each row is a designer's build of one idea, with a note saying where to look.	Nothing here is decided. A row may change from one day to the next, or disappear. That is the point of the section, not a fault.
Resources	Things that live elsewhere and are useful alongside the designs — briefs, boards, references.	Background reading. Open what is relevant to you.
Research	Where the reasoning behind decisions is catalogued, one entry per decision.	Open what is relevant. If it is empty, that is a true statement about this moment, not an error.
PRDs	The product requirements the designs answer.	The brief behind a screen, when you want to know what it was asked to do.
Explorations	Standalone documents — outside products and ideas rebuilt in our own styling.	Thinking, not product. Nothing here is proposed for building.

There are more sections in the rail than these — the ones grouped under **Dev Handoff** and **Team** are the team's own working surfaces (what engineering is building, what shipped, who is on what this week, and the guides). Nothing is locked; you are welcome in them, they are just not written for you. The numbers beside section names are counts of what is inside. The **Appearance** control at the foot of the rail changes the colour scheme of the Hub page only — it does not change the product you open from it.

03 Opening and driving the prototype

In **Prototypes**, leave the switch on **Main** and click the first row, *End-to-End User Experience*. The learner dashboard opens with a dark **review bar** across the top. That bar is scaffolding for reviewers; a learner would never see it. The rows under *Work in progress* open the same build at a different door — the invite and purchase flow, the learning Home, Compass — and **Stage** opens the same doors on the build that is waiting to be released, in a new tab.

The Demo Controls

The bar carries a few dropdowns that change *who* you are looking at, so one prototype can show many situations:

- **Persona** — named example learners with different circumstances.
- **Progress** — how far through the course the learner is (on track, at risk, and so on). The label is approximate; the page itself shows the exact figure.
- **Education** — pre-licensing versus continuing education, which changes the whole shape of the course.
- **Readiness** — how prepared for the state exam the learner is. Deliberately separate from Progress: a learner can be far through the course and not ready.

Change them freely. **Nothing you flip is saved** — the prototype opens in "demo mode", which shows the team's agreed configuration and forgets your changes when you leave. Reload and you are back at the baseline.

The left rail inside the product

Home · Study Plan · Readiness · My Courses · Certificates · Resources · Rubi Insights · Get Help. Each is a real section you can open. Some sections the team has built but chosen not to show on the rail (Learning Path, Browse Catalog, Podcasts among them); they are hidden, not gone, and a designer can show you one on request.

What the data is

The learner, their course and their progress are **demo fixtures**. Where a number is a real published fact — the New York state's 40 credit hours, the 70% pass mark, PSI's exam fee — it is real and sourced. Where the team has had to guess a figure XCEL has not published, the code marks it as

invented and the screen says so rather than presenting it as fact. If a number looks wrong to you, say so: that is exactly the kind of feedback the fixtures exist to draw out.

> **WORTH KNOWING**
> Dates in the prototype are anchored to a fixed "today" (11 May 2026) so that nothing ages into "eight months ago" between reviews. A countdown that seems not to move between visits is doing that on purpose.

04 Reading Refinement

Each row is a link plus a short note. The note is the designer telling you where to look and what question they are asking. Open the link, find the thing the note names, form a view.

REFINEMENT · EXAMPLE ROW

Study streak card — feat/study-streak-card
Home, under Current Progress. Is the streak motivating or nagging? · added 18 Sep · by Sam ↗

Three things to hold in mind while you look:

- **It is one idea, isolated.** A Refinement build is the agreed baseline *plus one change*, so what you see differing from Prototypes is the thing under discussion.
- **It may be mid-change.** The designer might push an update while you are looking. If a page reloads differently, that is why.
- **You see everything the team sees.** Since 15 October there is one list, not a public one and a private one. A row the designer has finished discussing is archived — hidden, not deleted — so what is on the board is what is open right now. The pills above the board filter it by designer.

If Refinement is empty, it says "Nothing is being shown for review right now." That is a true statement about this moment, not an error.

05 Giving feedback

The Hub has no comment box, on purpose — feedback belongs in the conversation the team is already having, where it can be answered. Send it to whoever shared the link with you, or to the design lead directly.

What makes feedback easy to act on:

- **Say which section and which row.** "Refinement → the study streak card" beats "the new thing".

- **Say which settings you had.** If it matters, name the Persona, Progress, Education and Readiness you were on. The same screen can look quite different across them.
- **Separate "this is wrong" from "I'd prefer".** Both are useful; they are answered differently. A wrong number gets fixed; a preference gets discussed.
- **Screenshots help**, with the browser's address bar visible — the address says exactly which build and which page you were on.

06 What else is here

Since 15 October there is one Hub for everyone, so the team's working surfaces are on this page too: developer hand-off notes and what has shipped (under *Dev Handoff*), QA findings, an archive of what was removed and how to bring it back, and the *To Do Board* — who is on what this week, as columns a card moves across. Nothing is locked; they are just not written for you. One column on the To Do Board is worth knowing: **On Stage** lists the work that is on Stage and waiting on a release, with the date it got there.

07 If something looks wrong

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT USUALLY MEANS	TRY
A page saying "There's nothing at this address"	Either a mistyped link, or a page that is not on the Hub.	Go back to the Hub and open things from there. If a link you were sent does this, tell the sender.
A Refinement link that won't load	The designer has just pushed a change and the new version is still being built (a couple of minutes).	Wait, then reload.
The prototype looks different from last time	Either the team has landed a change, or you were on a different Persona / Progress setting.	Check the Demo Controls; then check with the team whether Prototypes changed.
A "Not started" or empty screen	Probably a deliberate state — the fixtures cover the empty case as well as the busy one.	Change Progress or Readiness and see whether it fills in.
A figure marked as an estimate or invented	XCEL has not published that number yet; the team has flagged it rather than guessed silently.	If you know the real figure, that is the most useful feedback you can give.

08 Questions we get asked

Is this the real product?

No. It is a working prototype built on the same design system the product will use, so what you see is faithful to how it will look and behave — but the data is demo data and nothing you do here affects any learner.

Can I share the link?

Yes, with the password — there is one for the whole Hub, and the design lead gives it out. Please share both with people who are part of the review, not more widely; it is work in progress.

Can I change anything on the Hub page itself?

You can, in a few places — the boards (Refinement, Resources, Research, PRDs, QA Notes, the To Do Board) are authored on the page and nothing stops you. Please don't, unless the team has asked you to: the Hub has no sign-in, so an edit is anonymous and the team cannot tell who to ask about it. Your influence is your feedback, sent to the person who shared the link.

Something I saw last week has gone. Was it rejected?

Not necessarily. A Refinement row goes away when its idea was decided and shared to Stage (look at Prototypes → Stage, or Main once it is released), when it was parked, or when it was archived after discussion. Ask, and the team will tell you which.

What is the difference between Main and Stage?

Main is released; Stage is decided. A designer who owns a surface — Compass, say — puts their finished work on Stage when they are sure of it, and the design lead releases Stage to Main, everything at once. If you are reviewing what the product *is*, use Main. If you are previewing what it is *about to be*, use Stage. After a release the two are the same until the next piece lands on Stage.

Why does the prototype open with "?demo=1" in the address?

That switch tells the prototype to show the team's agreed configuration and to forget any settings you change. Keep it in the address when you share a link, so the next person sees the same thing you did.